

Lesson 2.1 – The Five Framings

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The same question gets asked five different ways. Each framing wants a different opening sentence. Use the wrong one and you sound deaf to the room.

By the end of this lesson:

- You'll recognize each framing in the first 10 seconds the interviewer speaks.
- You'll have an opening sentence ready for each one.
- You'll know which framings to lean into and which to deflect.

This is a *recognition* lesson. Read it twice. Then practice with a friend who asks you the question in different tones.

1. Why framing matters more than content

Two interviewers can ask the same words – “*Why do we still need human developers?*” – and want completely different answers.

- One is a tech lead who reads Hacker News and is genuinely worried.
- One is a CTO who has to defend the engineering budget to the board.
- One is a founder who's asking out loud what their investors are pestering them about.
- One is a peer engineer testing whether you've thought about your own role.
- One is a cynic who thinks engineering is overpaid and AI proves it.

Each one wants a different first sentence. If you give the budget-defending CTO a philosophical answer, you've missed. If you give the cynic a heartfelt answer, you've missed.

The skill: **identify the framing in the first 10 seconds**, then deliver the right opening sentence. The body of the answer can be similar; the framing-specific opener is what makes

it land.

2. Framing #1 – The Hostile Framing

How it sounds

"Honestly, I look at this stuff and I wonder why we hire any developers anymore. Convince me."

"Half my team is being asked to do twice the work because of AI. Are you worth what we pay engineers?"

"I've seen a single founder ship an entire SaaS app with AI alone. So why do I need a team of you?"

Tone signals

- The word "convince", "justify", "prove", "worth".
- A short, blunt question without the usual interview pleasantries.
- Eye contact that's holding you accountable, not warmly engaging.
- They lean back, not forward.

What they actually want

They want to feel that **you take the question seriously and have an answer**. They don't want a lecture about transformer architecture or a defensive rant. They want a senior engineer's quiet confidence.

The opening sentence

"That's a fair question and I think about it a lot. The short answer is that AI raised the floor of what's possible – but it didn't lower the ceiling of what's required from a senior engineer. Let me explain."

Notes:

- "Fair question" – disarms.
- "I think about it a lot" – signals you're not naive.

- *"Floor / ceiling"* — a clean metaphor that they'll repeat to colleagues.
- *"Let me explain"* — invites them to listen.

Then go into the 7-pillar framework (next lesson).

What not to do

- Don't smirk.
- Don't deflect (*"that's a complicated question..."*).
- Don't argue with the premise (*"AI hasn't actually replaced developers..."*) — that's a fight.

Validate, then redirect to the structural answer. **Always.**

3. Framing #2 — The Curious Framing

How it sounds

"What's your take on the whole AI-and-developers conversation?"

"How do you think your job has changed in the last 18 months?"

"Where do you see the most leverage from AI in your day-to-day, and where doesn't it help?"

Tone signals

- *"Your take", "how do you see", "what's interesting to you".*
- Open posture, leaning in.
- A genuine pause for you to answer, not a setup for their next point.

What they actually want

This is the **most generous framing**. The interviewer is curious, conversational, and probably as uncertain as you are. They want a thoughtful exchange, not a defended thesis.

The opening sentence

"My take is that AI has changed what I spend time on, more than it changed whether I'm needed. The typing got automated. The judgment didn't. If anything, the judgment got more important because there are more options to choose between."

Notes:

- *"What I spend time on"* – invites a conversation about your actual work.
- *"Typing automated, judgment didn't"* – clean, memorable.
- *"More options to choose between"* – a positive frame for the change.

Then invite their experience back: *"Has that been your experience too?"* This converts the question into a dialogue, which is exactly what this interviewer wants.

What not to do

- Don't over-prepare and deliver a monologue. They want a chat.
 - Don't be too humble (*"oh, I'm still figuring it out"*) – you'll sound junior.
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4. Framing #3 – The Technical Framing

How it sounds

"Where do current AI tools break down for you, technically?"

"What's a class of problem you would not let an LLM solve in production?"

"How do you reason about when to trust LLM output vs verify it manually?"

Tone signals

- They use precise vocabulary: *"in production"*, *"verify"*, *"class of problem"*.
- Specific examples or follow-up questions are likely.
- They're often a senior IC, not a manager.

What they actually want

They want **concrete technical opinions backed by examples**. They are the easiest framing to nail because they're testing your engineering thinking, not your soft skills.

The opening sentence

"There are three classes of work where I won't let the LLM be the primary author: anything that touches money, anything that requires reasoning across more than ~200 lines of unfamiliar context, and anything where the cost of a wrong answer doesn't show up in tests. Let me give you an example for each."

Notes:

- Three categories — concrete and memorable.
- "Primary author" — a precise distinction. The LLM can assist; it shouldn't drive.
- "Let me give you an example" — the next sentences will be stories, which interviewers love.

Then deliver three short stories. Aim for ~30 seconds each. Total answer ~2 minutes.

What not to do

- Don't be vague. Technical interviewers eat vagueness alive.
 - Don't say "it depends" without immediately specifying what it depends on.
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5. Framing #4 — The Business Framing

How it sounds

"From a hiring-manager perspective, why should I prioritize a human engineer over scaling AI tooling for my existing team?"

"How do you think about the ROI of a senior engineer vs an AI subscription?"

"If we doubled our AI tooling spend, what would still be missing?"

Tone signals

- Words from the budget conversation: "ROI", "priority", "spend", "hire".

- Often a director, VP, or non-IC.
- They're pattern-matching against other hires they've made.

What they actually want

They want the answer they can **paraphrase to their own boss** when asked why they hired you instead of buying more AI seats. Give them the line they'll repeat.

The opening sentence

"AI tools are force multipliers. Force multipliers don't help if you don't have force. The engineer is the force – the judgment about what to build, the design choices about how it fits, the accountability when it breaks. AI subscription doesn't show up to the postmortem. I do."

Notes:

- "Force multiplier" – borrowed from military/business vocabulary they'll respect.
- "Force" – your value, framed in their language.
- "Postmortem" – accountability, the word managers most want to hear.
- The last line is **memorable**. They will repeat it.

Then translate into one or two business stories: a feature shipped, a fire put out, a decision made. Use words like *outcome, margin, runway, unblocked*.

What not to do

- Don't go technical. They don't care about transformer hallucination rates.
- Don't get philosophical. They want concrete value.
- Don't be modest. This is the framing where confidence is most rewarded.

6. Framing #5 – The Existential Framing

How it sounds

"Are you worried about your career?"

"Do you think this profession will exist in 10 years?"

"How do you tell a junior developer to start a career in 2026 with all this happening?"

Tone signals

- The question is broader than the role. It's about *the field, the future, careers*.
- Often slightly personal – they're vulnerable too, even if they're hiring.
- Pause-laden, less briskly transactional than the hostile framing.

What they actually want

They want a **sober, honest, optimistic answer**. They want to feel the energy in the room shift from anxious to constructive. Done well, this is the framing where you most build genuine rapport.

The opening sentence

"I'm thoughtful about it but not worried. The work is changing – not vanishing. The people who will struggle are the ones who tied their identity to typing code. The people who'll thrive are the ones who tied their identity to making good engineering decisions. I'm in the second camp, and I'd advise a junior to be in the second camp too."

Notes:

- *"Thoughtful but not worried"* – the precise emotional register.
- *"Identity to typing"* vs *"identity to decisions"* – a frame they'll repeat.
- *"I'd advise a junior to..."* – converts the question into mentorship vibes.

Then add one personal touch: a real worry you've had and worked through, a friend who pivoted, a mentor's advice. Make it specific.

What not to do

- Don't catastrophize.
- Don't be saccharine (*"I think humans will always have a place..."*) – sounds rehearsed.
- Don't pivot too quickly to mechanics. This framing wants 30 seconds of genuine reflection first.

7. The decision tree (memorize this)

Here is the live-decision flowchart for the first 10 seconds of any question that mentions AI and human developers in the same breath.

Did they use words like "convince me", "worth", "justify"?

└ YES → HOSTILE framing → opener from §2

└ NO →

Did they ask "what's your take" / "how do you see"?

└ YES → CURIOUS framing → opener from §3

└ NO →

Did they ask about specific cases ("class of problem", "in production")?

└ YES → TECHNICAL framing → opener from §4

└ NO →

Did they use ROI / budget / hiring language?

└ YES → BUSINESS framing → opener from §5

└ NO → EXISTENTIAL framing → opener from §6

In practice, you'll often catch the framing in the *tone* before the words finish. Trust your instinct — if you've drilled the openers, you'll reach for the right one automatically.

8. The seven-pillar bridge

Whichever opener you use, you eventually transition to the same body. The transition is:

"There are seven things humans still bring that AI does not. Let me run through them quickly."

Then you go into Lesson 2's pillars. **The opener changes by framing. The body does not.** That's why this lesson is recognition-only — once you can identify the framing, the rest of your answer is consistent.

9. Practice exercise

Have a friend (or a willing mentor) read these prompts to you, in a *random order*, in their natural speaking voice. Your job is to:

1. Identify the framing within 5 seconds.
2. Deliver the opener for that framing.
3. Bridge into the seven pillars.

Prompts:

- *"Honestly, why are you still relevant?"*
- *"What's your hot take on AI replacing developers?"*
- *"Where does GPT actually break down for you?"*
- *"From a hiring-manager perspective, what's the case for a human over AI tooling?"*
- *"Are you nervous about all this?"*
- *"Convince me you're not just a typing-cost we could automate."*
- *"What's a problem you wouldn't trust an LLM with?"*
- *"What would you tell a college student majoring in CS this year?"*

Aim for under 10 seconds between hearing the prompt and starting the opener.

10. Common mistakes by framing

Framing	Common mistake	Fix
Hostile	Defensiveness	Open with <i>"That's a fair question..."</i>
Curious	Monologue	Hand the question back: <i>"Has that been your experience?"</i>

Framing	Common mistake	Fix
Technical	Vagueness	Lead with three concrete categories
Business	Tech jargon	Lead with <i>"force multiplier"</i> / <i>"accountability"</i>
Existential	Catastrophizing or fluff	Lead with <i>"thoughtful but not worried"</i>

Highlight your own pattern. Most engineers gravitate toward one mistake — the one closest to their natural personality. Once you know which one is yours, drill against it.

11. CHECK YOURSELF

- ☐ Can you list the 5 framings without notes?
 - ☐ Can you state the opener for each framing without notes?
 - ☐ Can a friend ask you a sample of each, and can you identify the framing within 10 seconds?
 - ☐ Do you know which framing matches your natural strengths and which one you have to drill?
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12. Where you are now

You can now diagnose what kind of "human vs AI" question you're being asked. Move on to [02-the-seven-pillars.md](#) — the universal body of the answer that every framing eventually

deserves.